

El lado lúdico de la traducción

Maira Chaves

El presente trabajo constituye la extensión de una consigna presentada en la materia Estructuras Comparadas, dictada por la Profesora Delma Sánchez. Su principal objetivo es poder brindar una idea general de la forma en que lo lúdico es utilizado como recurso de traducción en diversos aspectos.

Ludic translation: contrastive analysis and the use of memes and poetry

Ludic translation refers to the playful and creative translation of texts, often incorporating puns, wordplay, and other literary devices. It can be used in various contexts, including literature, advertising, and social media.

Different techniques used in each language to create playful language:

Wordplay: English and Spanish have different sounds, vocabulary, and grammar structures that can affect the types of wordplay that are possible. Puns and double entendres (figure of speech that is devised to have a double meaning, of which one is typically obvious, whereas the other often conveys a message that would be socially awkward) may rely on the similarity between two words that sound alike in English, but have different meanings in Spanish.

For example: "Time flies like an arrow; fruit flies like a banana." It is an old idiom that means time passes quickly, subjectively.

Modern English speakers understand the sentence to unambiguously mean "Time passes fast as an arrow travels."

Time flies like an arrow = time passes in the manner of an arrow.

Fruit flies like a banana = the insects known as 'fruit flies' have a strong desire for bananas.

In Spanish, puns may rely on the similarity of two words with the same or similar meanings. For example, "Un astrónomo es un loco con un telescopio"; "An astronomer is a crazy person with a telescope".

Cultural references: Ludic translation often involves references to popular culture, literature, and history. English and Spanish have different cultural touchstones that can be used in this way, such as TV shows, music, and sports teams.

English: "May the force be with you." - This phrase from the Star Wars franchise has become a cultural touchstone in English, often used as a farewell or as a way to express support.

Spanish: "Que la fuerza te acompañe." - The Spanish translation of this phrase is widely recognized among Spanish-speaking audiences, but may not have the same level of cultural significance as in English.

Syntax and grammar: The structure of sentences and phrases in English and Spanish can affect the way that ludic translation works. For example, English allows for more flexibility in word order than Spanish, which has more rigid rules about subject-verb agreement and adjective placement.

For example, the sentence "The cat ate the fish" can be rearranged to "The fish was eaten by the cat" without changing the meaning.

In Spanish, the subject and verb must agree in number and gender, and adjectives often come after the noun. For example, "El gato negro" (The black cat) cannot be reversed to "Negro el gato" without changing the meaning.

Humour styles: English and Spanish speakers may have different preferences when it comes to humour. For example, English speakers may be more likely to appreciate irony and sarcasm, while Spanish speakers may prefer slapstick (a type of humorous acting in which the actors behave in a silly way, such as by throwing things, falling over, etc) and physical comedy.

For example, the British sitcom *The Office* is known for its dry, sarcastic humour.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1QQBB3cwNM0&t=27s>

In Spanish, for example, the TV show *El Chavo del Ocho* is known for its physical comedy and exaggerated facial expressions.
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_BYZKU_XV1KA

Context and audience: The way that ludic translation is used may vary depending on the context and audience. For example, a meme that is popular in one country may not resonate with people from another culture, even if the translation is accurate.

English: "To be or not to be, that is the question".

Spanish: "Ser o no ser, esa es la cuestión".

This famous line from Shakespeare's *Hamlet* is translated fairly directly in both English and Spanish, with only slight modifications in word choice and phrasing. However, the choice of words and phrasing in the Spanish version is influenced by the cultural context and audience. The Spanish version uses "cuestión" instead of "pregunta" to better capture the sense of a complex and difficult decision. Additionally, the Spanish version uses the familiar "ser o no ser" construction, which is more idiomatic in Spanish, rather than

the inverted "to be or not to be" phrasing used in English.

Similarities

Phonetics: Both English and Spanish have a variety of sounds that can be used for ludic translation, such as alliteration and rhyme.

English: "How much wood would a woodchuck chuck, if a woodchuck could chuck wood?"

Spanish: "¿Cuánta leña podría cortar un leñador, si un leñador pudiera cortar leña?"

In both examples, the use of alliteration and repetition creates a playful and tongue-twisting effect, making it a fun and engaging way to play with language.

Idioms: Both languages have a variety of idiomatic expressions that can be used for ludic translation.

English: "To kill two birds with one stone"

Spanish: "Matar dos pájaros de un tiro"

In English, this idiom means to accomplish two things at once with a single action. In Spanish, the equivalent idiom is "Matar dos pájaros de un tiro," which literally translates to "to kill two birds with one shot." While both idioms use the same basic metaphor, the Spanish version is more direct and violent, using the image of a gunshot instead of a stone.

Creativity: Both languages can be used creatively for ludic translation, allowing for a range of playful language techniques.

English: "A picture is worth a thousand words."

Spanish: "Una imagen vale más que mil palabras."

These phrases have been creatively adapted to each language, demonstrating how ludic translation can play with language and create new variations of familiar expressions. This can help translators and creators to develop

effective strategies for creating playful language that resonates with audiences in both languages.

In memes, ludic translation often involves taking a popular image or format and using creative language to put a new spin on the joke or concept.

For example, the popular "**Distracted Boyfriend**" meme format features a man looking at another woman while his girlfriend looks on in disapproval. Ludic translation could involve changing the caption to incorporate a pun or wordplay that plays off the visual elements of the image.



This is fine

Taken out of a 2013 webcomic strip called "**On Fire**," this image showing a human-like dog enjoying his coffee while his house is burning down has seemingly become more and more relatable every year. The image is rarely altered, simply attached to troubling or hard-to-grasp news.



We can find this meme in the Spanish version, but it's commonly used in English.

**Cuando todo te va mal pero
no quieres preocupar a nadie:**



On Twitter, for example, someone might write some troubling news and attach the image.

A popular meme format in Spanish is the "**Pikachu shock**" meme, which typically features an image of Pikachu with an exaggerated expression of shock or surprise. The text captions often use regional slang or cultural references to create a playful effect.

Yo cuando me entero que hay un meme de pikachu de mejor calidad y en hd



Horoscope: You're probably breathing right now

People:



Then, we have some examples of memes that are written wrongly on purpose just to create a wordplay.

- El mes pasado contraí matrimonio.
- Contraje.
- Claro, tenía que ser formal.



Rhetorical structures are used differently for humour. According to linguistic and syntactic studies started by the contrastive rhetoric patterns of Robert Kaplan, English seems to favour a rhetoric pattern that presents arguments by following a straight line, while Spanish speakers prefer a digressive style that requires readers to follow different directions towards a conclusion.

English audiences usually seem to favour precise jokes that take word economy into account. English sentences are shorter, packing more information in less syllables, which means the surprise of a punchline can be more explosive.

Physical humour, repetition, hyperbole, and satire seem to work best in Latin America, where humour tends to be more direct, more aggressive and more visceral. English-speaking audiences lean more toward irony, surprise and sarcasm.

In poetry, ludic translation can involve playing with language in a way that is both creative and meaningful. Poets might use puns, wordplay, or other forms of playful language to convey a deeper meaning or to create a sense of whimsy or humour. For example, the poet E.E. Cummings is known for his playful use of language and typography, often breaking words and phrases into unconventional arrangements to create new meanings and associations.

Excerpt from "Anyone lived in a pretty how town" by E.E Cummings:

"Anyone lived in a pretty how town
(With up so floating many bells down)
spring summer autumn winter
he sang his didn't he danced his did."

This excerpt is an example of ludic translation in poetry. Cummings uses playful language and unconventional word arrangements to create a sense of whimsy and wonder in the poem. The phrase "**pretty how town**" is a play on words that creates a sense of ambiguity and mystery, while the repetition of the words "**didn't**" and "**did**" creates a rhythm and sense of movement in the poem. The overall effect is a poem that is both playful and profound, using language to create meaning in unexpected ways.

English has a long history of playful language in literature, from the works of Shakespeare to the nonsense poetry of Lewis Carroll. Spanish, on the other hand, has a rich tradition of poetic language that often emphasizes form and structure. This can make ludic translation more challenging, as it may require a departure from traditional poetic conventions.

In "Don Quijote de la Mancha" by Miguel de Cervantes, the author creates playful language through puns and wordplay. For example, the character Sancho Panza says "Bien haya quien bien te quiere" (meaning "blessed be he who loves you well"), but Don Quijote hears "Bien haya el que me roba y bien me quiere" (meaning "blessed be he who steals from me and loves me well"), creating a humorous misunderstanding.

Excerpt from "**The Road Not Taken**" by Robert Frost:

English original:

Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
I took the one less travelled by,
And that has made all the difference.

Spanish translation:

Option 1

Dos caminos se bifurcaban en un bosque, y
yo

tomé el menos transitado,
y eso hizo toda la diferencia.

Option 2:

Dos caminos en el bosque había,
y por el que menos transitado opté,
eso, amigos, ha marcado la ida.

Analysis

We can say that the first translation tries to keep a similar structure from its original, where the sense and the musical characteristic of the poem are highlighted.

In the second translation, we can observe a more colloquial structure introducing rhymes and wordplays to give the poem a ludic aspect.

Here are some other techniques we can use to create playful language

Metaphors: Using creative comparisons to create a playful and imaginative image.

Example in English: "Life is a rollercoaster, full of ups and downs"

Example in Spanish: "La vida es una montaña rusa, llena de altibajos"

Irony: Both English and Spanish use irony to create playful language, but the cultural context and idiomatic expressions may differ, leading to potential contrasts in interpretation.

Example in English: "I can resist everything except temptation."

Here, the irony lies in the fact that the speaker claims to have great willpower but then admits to being easily tempted.

Example in Spanish: "Cuando el río suena, agua lleva."

Here, the irony lies in the fact that the proverb suggests that rumours or gossip are usually true, but in reality, this is not always the case.

Hyperbole: Exaggerating something to create a playful effect.

English example: "I'm so hungry, I could eat a horse" (exaggerating hunger)

Spanish example: "Eres más lento que una tortuga" (exaggerating someone's slowness)

Personification: Giving human characteristics to non-human objects or animals to create a playful image.

English example: "The wind whispered secrets through the trees."

The wind is personified as a whisperer, as if it has the ability to speak and share secrets. This creates a playful and imaginative tone in the sentence.

Spanish example: "Los árboles suspiraban al compás del viento."

In this example, the trees are personified as if they were breathing, by describing them as "sighing" in rhythm with the wind. This creates a playful and poetic tone in the sentence.

Rhyme: The patterns and sounds used in rhyming may differ between the two languages.

English example: "Twinkle, twinkle, little star / How I wonder what you are"

Spanish example: "La rima es lo que es, y lo que no es es verso"

Onomatopoeia: Using words that imitate sounds to create a playful effect.

English example: "Buzz" (sound of a bee).

Spanish example: "Miau" (sound of a cat meowing).

Antithesis: Contrasting two opposite ideas to create a playful effect.

English example: "It was the best of times, it was the worst of times"

Spanish example: "Tu blanco, yo negro; tu rico, yo pobre"

Alliteration: Repeating consonant sounds in words to create a playful sound effect.

English example: Sally sells seashells by the seashore.

Spanish example: Tres tristes tigres comen trigo en un trigal. (Three sad tigers were eating wheat in a wheat field)

Paradox: Using contradictory statements to create a playful or ironic effect.

English example: "Less is more" (Ludwig Mies van der Rohe)

Spanish example: "Solo sé que no sé nada" (Socrates)

More examples

"Kick the bucket" → "Estirar la pata"

"To get to the point" → "Ir al grano"

"To get one's act together"/ "To buck one's ideas up" → "Ponerse las pilas", "Avivarse" más colloquial.

"To cost an arm and a leg" → "Costar un ojo de la cara"

"To each their own" → "Cada loco con su tema", "a cada uno lo suyo"

The results of ludic translation in both languages can vary, but generally, it can add humour, playfulness, and creativity to a text. However, it is important to note that ludic translation should be used with caution, as it can also lead to misinterpretations if not done correctly.

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Maira Chaves tiene 25 años. Comenzó a estudiar inglés a los 6 años, sin imaginar que se iba a convertir en una de sus prioridades a futuro. Hoy en día se encuentra transitando el último tramo de su carrera en la Universidad Nacional de Lanús y busca especializarse en el área de marketing.